

FREE GUIDE

The Solopreneur's Marketing Stack

5 Free Tools That Do the Work of a \$500/Month Marketing Agency

You don't need a big budget or a team of marketers to compete. This guide shows you the exact tools used to build a fully automated marketing system — email list, funnels, AI content, and analytics — for less than the cost of a single agency retainer.

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Why Most Solopreneurs Overpay for Marketing

Here's a conversation I have all the time:

A solopreneur tells me they're spending \$300-500 a month on marketing tools — an email platform here, a funnel builder there, a scheduling tool, a design app — and they're still not seeing results. Not because the tools are bad. Because they're paying for overlap, complexity, and features they don't use.

The truth is, you can run a serious marketing operation in 2026 with free tools. Not hobbled, feature-limited free tools. Actually good ones.

This guide covers the five tools I recommend to every solopreneur I work with. Together they handle:

- Building and managing your email list
- Creating sales funnels and landing pages
- Writing content with AI assistance
- Designing professional graphics
- Automating repetitive marketing tasks

Total monthly cost to get started: \$0.

Let's get into it.

Tool 01

Systeme.io

Funnels, Email Marketing & Automation — All in One

If I could only recommend one tool to a solopreneur starting from zero, it would be Systeme.io.

Most platforms charge separately for email marketing, funnel builders, and automation. Systeme.io bundles all three — and their free plan is genuinely usable, not a stripped-down demo.

What you get for free:

- Up to 2,000 subscribers
- Unlimited emails
- 3 sales funnels
- 1 automation rule
- 1 membership site
- Basic email campaigns and broadcasts

For most solopreneurs, the free plan is all they need for the first 6-12 months. By the time you outgrow it, you'll have the revenue to justify upgrading.

Best for: Anyone building their first email list or sales funnel.

Get started free: <https://greatowlmarketing.com/recommends/systeme>

Resend.com

Transactional Email — Reliable Delivery at No Cost

Resend is the email sending infrastructure that powers Great Owl Marketing's own emails. It's built for developers but straightforward enough for anyone to use via their API.

The key difference between Resend and traditional email platforms: Resend focuses on deliverability. Your emails actually land in the inbox instead of the spam folder — which is the most important metric in email marketing.

What you get for free:

- 3,000 emails per month
- 100 emails per day
- 1 custom domain
- Full API access
- Email logs and analytics

For a growing list under 3,000 monthly sends, Resend's free tier is all you need. It pairs perfectly with Systeme.io — use Systeme for broadcasts and Resend for automated transactional emails like welcome sequences.

Best for: Automated welcome emails, sequence delivery, and transactional messages.

Get started: resend.com

Claude by Anthropic

AI Writing Assistant — Your On-Demand Copywriter

Content is the fuel that drives every marketing strategy — social posts, email sequences, landing page copy, blog articles. The problem for most solopreneurs is time. Writing good content consistently is hard.

Claude is an AI assistant made by Anthropic that I use daily for marketing content. It's better than ChatGPT for nuanced, human-sounding writing — which matters when you're trying to build trust with an audience.

What you can do with it:

- Draft email sequences in minutes
- Write social media captions for a full week
- Generate landing page copy from a brief
- Create lead magnets like this one
- Brainstorm content ideas when you're stuck
- Rewrite and improve your existing content

The free plan at claude.ai gives you access to powerful models with daily usage limits — more than enough to support a solopreneur's content needs.

Pro tip: *Always edit AI output to add your voice. Use it as a first draft, not a final product.*

Get started: claude.ai

Canva

Design — Professional Graphics Without a Designer

You don't need to be a designer to create professional-looking marketing materials. Canva's free plan gives you everything a solopreneur needs to produce graphics that look like they cost money.

What you can create:

- Instagram and Facebook posts
- Lead magnets and PDF guides
- Email headers and banners
- Logo and brand assets
- Presentation decks
- Social media story templates

The free plan has thousands of templates and is more than sufficient for most solopreneurs. Canva Pro (\$15/month) adds brand kits, background removal, and a larger asset library — worth it once you're producing content consistently.

Best for: Anyone who needs to create visual content without hiring a designer.

Get started: canva.com

Make.com

Automation — Connect Your Tools Without Code

The most successful solopreneurs aren't working more hours — they're automating repetitive tasks so their marketing runs while they sleep. Make.com is how you do that without writing a single line of code.

Make lets you build visual workflows that connect your apps. When someone fills out a form, Make can add them to your email list, send a notification to Slack, create a row in a spreadsheet, and tag them in your CRM — all automatically.

What you get for free:

- 1,000 operations per month
- Access to 1,500+ app integrations
- Visual workflow builder
- Basic scheduling

For a solopreneur just getting started, 1,000 operations a month is plenty. As you grow, the Core plan at \$10/month unlocks real-time automation and more operations.

Best for: Connecting Systeme.io, your email tools, social media, and CRM without manual work.

Get started: make.com

Your Next Step

You now have everything you need to build a real marketing operation without spending a dollar.

Here's the order I'd tackle it:

- 1 Set up Systeme.io**
Create your free account and build one simple landing page with an opt-in form.
- 2 Create one lead magnet**
A one-page checklist or short guide your audience actually wants. Use Claude to write it, Canva to design it.
- 3 Write a 5-email welcome sequence**
Use Claude to draft it. Keep it simple: welcome, your story, your best tip, a tool recommendation, a soft ask.
- 4 Pick one traffic source**
Instagram, Facebook, LinkedIn — choose one and post consistently for 30 days before expanding.
- 5 Automate what you can**
Use Make.com to connect your tools. Start simple and build from there.

Ready to build your first funnel?

Start with Systeme.io — it's free and handles steps 1-3 above.

<https://greatowlmarketing.com/recommends/systeme>

Questions? Reply to any email from Great Owl Marketing — John reads every one.